

Q. Could you briefly give some background about Amadeus and its presence in India?

A. Amadeus is the world's largest technology provider for the travel industry. We're a 37-year-old company, headquartered in Madrid and have more than 19,000 employees working in various offices worldwide. We've developed the technology on which the travel industry transacts its business, be it the sale of tickets for airlines, room nights, car rentals, and so on. We have a vast network of travel agencies on our platform.

Further, we facilitate the inventory being sold to travellers like you and me. And this is one of our largest verticals. We have a second vertical made up of IT business for airlines, hotel chains, car rental companies, and so on. We also play in adjacent businesses like payments for the travel industry, and the IT for airports. So, Amadeus has the solutions for almost everything related to the travel life cycle and its several stages.

The 11-year-old Bengaluru centre is our second largest engineering and R&D centre worldwide. Here, we have over 3000 engineers innovating on several aspects of our platform. And so, we cater to solutions not only for the global travel ecosystem but also act as the engineering hub for the APAC region, based in India.

Q. I want to understand how, despite several startups coming in, Amadeus has been able to survive and thrive in the terminals of almost all travel agents.

A. We are a SaaS platform provider, and our primary and sole customer base is our network of businesses present in the travel industry. So we are a B2B player, or rather, a B2B2C player where we make sure that using our technology and platform, travel providers like the airlines, the hotel chains, the car rental companies, and the travel agencies make

it a better experience for travellers. I would say that we provide the backbone. We are not a B2C player like the new dot coms coming in. In the background, the Amadeus platform is being used for every second traveller's journey.

Q. Does that mean that you partner with them rather than them entering into your space?

A. Absolutely, we facilitate online travel agencies, like MakeMyTrip, Expedia, etc, to have more innovative solutions, and thereby cater to the more personalised needs of travellers. While the transaction happens on the online travel agency's portal, in the background, it's Amadeus.

Q. Have none of them ever attempted to come to the B2B side also?

A. For sure, the industry is evolving into a more open platform. It is happening because all the players in the travel space understand that there is a lot of friction here. We understand that the industry works on a complex network. You could be sitting in Delhi booking a ticket between Dallas and Johannesburg, using a Bengaluru-based online travel agency, a US-based payment provider, and two different airlines. And this is a common scenario in the travel industry!

Each player is now trying to find out how to stand apart from the others. So, the question is, how do you make the service a lot more personalised? How does an airline or a travel agency profile its customers, i.e., travellers, better? That's why the industry is evolving into a more open space.

And there are more and more players coming in including the larger hyper scalars and the e-commerce players, because travel is such a wide industry and a basic need. More players coming in necessitates an open platform. And that's the responsibility we carry as a large technology player

in the industry—to open up the platform so that more players can come in to create innovative solutions for travellers, and reduce any friction as they flow through.

Q. Am I correct to understand that the more the B2C players come into the industry, the better it is for Amadeus? Because they are your customers in a way and, through them, you are able to reach out to even more customers.

A. You're absolutely right. The more players that are innovating in the travel industry, the better the travellers' experience gets. We have several niche players who solve a point problem for the travel industry. For example, there are startups that use IoT and focus on tracking the baggage in an airport and keeping a traveller informed. As we have our own solutions for ground handlers, we ask, can we partner with one of these startups and make a better solution for travellers? In the end, we bring these point solutions to life and make the overall journey smoother on the tech front.

Q. How would you define the word 'open platform'? Is it different from 'open source'? Please shed some light on that.

A. What we have in Amadeus is a two-sided model. Let me give an example of air travel. What are the airlines looking for? All of them have an inventory of airline seats to sell, and they want to reach out to as many travellers in the world as possible. They do that through a network of travel sellers, who are a part of brick-and-mortar or online travel agencies.

When I say the more open the platform, the better—it's for all the players. It's a two-sided model. Let's say there are more travel agencies on the platform. It obviously increases the reach of travel providers and vice versa. The travel sellers are also